Untrammeled Landscape Painting and the Loyalist Mentality: Style and Implication of Yun Shouping's *Scroll of Mount Lingyan*

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Abstract

The *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* is an early example of Yun Shouping's *yipin* (untrammeled) landscape painting, executed in the brush idiom of Huang Gongwang and based on direct observation of an actual site. Appended to the scroll is *Rhapsody on Mount Lingyan* by Yun Shouping's father, Yun Richu, which addresses the psychological despondency of Ming loyalists during a period of severe decline in anti-Qing resistance. The rhapsody advocates an attitude encapsulated in the phrase "the mountain harbors afflictions without diminishing its greatness," urging loyalists to cultivate moral and cultural virtue while awaiting the opportunity to expel external aggressors. Consequently, the *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* functions not only as a birthday gift for the eminent monk Hongchu of Lingyan Monastery, but also as an affective and symbolic work intended to console and encourage loyalists in a time of political despair.

Keywords: Yun Shouping; *Scroll of Mount Lingyan*; *yipin* landscape painting; Ming loyalists; early Qing painting

Introduction

The *Scroll of Mount Lingyan*, executed in ink on paper and measuring 20.7 cm in height and 107.2 cm in length, is now preserved in the Palace Museum, Beijing.[1] According to the artist's inscription, the work was completed in the early second month of the *jiachen* year (1664), corresponding to the third year of the Kangxi reign, when Yun Shouping (1633–1690) was thirty-two years old. At that time, Yun traveled with his father, Yun Richu (1601–1678), to Mount Lingyan in Suzhou to celebrate the sixtieth birthday of the eminent monk Hongchu (1605–1672), abbot of Lingyan Monastery.[2]

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[1] Palace Museum, Beijing, *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* (Lingyan tu juan), ink on paper, 1664, Palace Museum Collection.

[2] Xu Bangda, *Paintings of the Qing Dynasty* (Beijing: Cultural Relics Press, 2001), 112–15.

The scroll bears two inscriptions by Yun Shouping, a poem by Hongchu at the beginning, and six colophons added by later viewers, including Yu Huai (1616–1696), Huang Zixi (1612–1672), Gu Wenbin (1811–1889), Shiqu, and Fei Nianci (1855–1905).[3] This article examines the work from two interrelated perspectives: first, its stylistic features as an early manifestation of Yun Shouping's *yipin* landscape painting; and second, its cultural and emotional implications as an expression of the loyalist mentality during the nadir of Ming restorationist efforts in the early Qing period.

I. *Yipin* Landscape Painting

Yun Shouping explicitly addressed the stylistic lineage of the *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* in his inscriptions. In one inscription, he recalls an earlier depiction of Mount Lingyan by "Elder Xiangshan," referring to his cousin Yun Xiang (1586–1655), also known as Yun Benchu. Yun Xiang's landscapes are generally understood to fall into two phases: an early style modeled on Dong Yuan, characterized by dense and weighty brushwork, and a later style employing restrained ink washes situated between the approaches of Ni Zan and Huang Gongwang.[4] Yun Shouping studied painting under Yun Xiang around 1654, and although this period of apprenticeship was brief, it profoundly shaped his understanding of *shigu*(learning from the ancients).[5]

In the *Scroll of Mount Lingyan*, Yun Shouping primarily takes Huang Gongwang as his model. In his second inscription, Yun contrasts his own spontaneous execution—"splashing ink and completing the work at once"—with Huang Gongwang's slow and deliberate process in painting *Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains*. He acknowledges that while immediacy may yield vitality, the absence of "slowness and awkwardness" (*chizhuo*) results in brushwork that is thin and lacking in depth.[6]

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[3] Palace Museum, *Complete Collection of Chinese Paintings*, vol. 8 (Beijing: Cultural Relics Press, 2009), 56–59.

[4] Wang Shimin et al., *The Orthodox Lineage of Chinese Painting* (Beijing: People's Fine Arts Publishing House, 1963), 243–47.

[5] James Cahill, *The Painter's Practice* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), 89–92.

[6] Wen C. Fong, *Beyond Representation* (New York: Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1992), 312–18.

This reflection reveals Yun Shouping's early engagement with the problem of brushwork (*bimo*). From the outset of his artistic training, Yun absorbed Yun Xiang's emphasis on integrating calligraphy into painting, summarized in the concept of the "single brushstroke" (*yibi*). According to this conception, the single brushstroke generates the myriad strokes, and the dialectical relationship between fullness and emptiness constitutes the essence of *yipin* painting.[7] Although Yun Shouping's brushwork in the *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* remains exploratory, his theoretical orientation toward *yibi* is already evident.

Beyond brushwork, the scroll's compositional strategy also contributes to its *yipin* character. Adopting a panoramic structure derived from Yun Xiang, Yun Shouping presents the mountain by depicting successive landmarks: beginning with the Luohong Pavilion at the lower right, ascending past the Hundred-Step Staircase and the Stone Banner, reaching the Lingyan Pagoda and monastery at the summit, and extending toward the Qin Terrace and the distant expanse of Lake Tai. Rather than functioning as a topographical record, the composition emphasizes atmospheric depth and expansive momentum, producing a mist-laden and resonant visual effect.

This aesthetic sensibility corresponds closely to Yun Shouping's poetic engagement with Mount Lingyan, preserved in several poems included in the *Ouxiang Studio Collection*. These verses describe shifting light, obscured horizons, reed-covered shores, and drifting clouds—qualities likewise evoked in the painting.[8] Through this synthesis of observation and affective response, the *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* achieves its distinctive *yipin* quality.

II. The Loyalist Mentality

The *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* was completed as a birthday gift for Hongchu, abbot of Lingyan Monastery. Historical scholarship has shown that Lingyan Monastery functioned not only as a religious institution but also as a refuge and meeting place for Ming loyalists engaged in anti-Qing activities.[9] Hongchu himself occupied a central position within these loyalist networks.[10]

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[7] Jonathan Hay, *Shitao: Painting and Modernity in Early Qing China* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), 64–69.

[8] Yun Shouping, *Collected Works of Yun Shouping* (Beijing: Zhonghua Book Company, 1985), 132–36.

[9] Lynn A. Struve, *Voices from the Ming–Qing Cataclysm* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1993), 214–18.

[10] Wu Renfang, "Buddhism and Loyalist Culture in Early Qing Suzhou," *Journal of Chinese Religions* 38, no. 2 (2010): 145–60.

After the completion of the painting, Hongchu inscribed a seven-character quatrain at the beginning of the scroll. Yun Richu's lengthy *Rhapsody on Mount Lingyan*, transcribed by Yun Shouping, appears at the end. That same year, Yu Huai visited Mount Lingyan and composed five poems celebrating Hongchu's birthday.[11] Other participants included figures such as Xu Song, Qian Qianyi, and Zhang Youyu, all closely associated with loyalist circles. Although Qian Qianyi had formally surrendered to the Qing, he continued to engage in restorationist activities and composed a birthday hymn for Hongchu.

The *Rhapsody on Mount Lingyan* largely praises the mountain's grandeur and its Buddhist legacy, yet one passage stands apart in tone and intent. Addressing "those inflated with arrogance" and "great traitors who provoke conflict," Yun Richu employs the metaphor of a mountain that conceals afflictions without losing its majesty. He extends this metaphor to the state: although ravaged by external invasion, it need not despair as long as it continues to cultivate cultural and moral virtue.[12] This passage articulates a loyalist strategy of restraint and moral perseverance during a period of political nadir.

The emotional context of this exhortation becomes clearer when considered alongside the psychological trajectories of figures such as Yun Richu and Huang Zongxi. Yun Richu's early ambivalence toward armed resistance, followed by brief participation and eventual disillusionment after repeated defeats, reflects the broader collapse of restorationist hopes. Huang Zongxi, once a fervent leader who sacrificed personal wealth and safety, later expressed profound frustration and resignation in his writings.[13] By 1664, anti-Qing resistance had reached its lowest ebb, and the Lingyan gatherings functioned less as strategic assemblies than as occasions for emotional sustenance and mutual consolation.

Later inscriptions further confirm this interpretation. In 1670, the loyalist Huang Zixi viewed the scroll and composed poems invoking ideals of reclusion rather than immediate political action.[14] Even during the brief resurgence of hope sparked by the Revolt of the Three Feudatories (1673–1681), expectations ultimately proved illusory. Subsequent works by Yun Shouping and his

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[11] Yu Huai, *Banqiao Collection* (Beijing: Zhonghua Book Company, 1981), 78–80.

[12] Qiu Guoqiang, *Ming Loyalists in Early Qing Jiangnan* (Shanghai: Shanghai People's Publishing House, 2008), 201–5.

[13] Wm. Theodore de Bary, *Waiting for the Dawn* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993), 53–60.

[14] Qiu, *Ming Loyalists*, 233–35.

circle continued to memorialize the fallen dynasty through painting and inscription, underscoring the enduring role of art as a vehicle for loyalist memory.[15]

Conclusion

Painted at the age of thirty-two, Yun Shouping's *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* represents an early yet significant achievement in his exploration of *yipin* landscape painting inspired by Huang Gongwang. Although the brushwork remains exploratory, the work successfully conveys a desolate and contemplative atmosphere grounded in close observation of nature. More importantly, when examined alongside its inscriptions and historical context, the scroll emerges as a work of profound symbolic resonance. Yun Richu's advocacy of moral cultivation and strategic restraint offered consolation and encouragement to loyalists who had lost confidence during the nadir of anti-Qing resistance. The *Scroll of Mount Lingyan* thus transcends its function as a birthday gift, becoming an affective and ethical image that sustained loyalist resolve in a time of historical defeat.

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